

Game Design Document

[Ruler of the Tomb]

General Information	2
Story & Setting	3
Gameplay Loop	4
Unique Mechanic	5
Game Rules	6
Enemies and Obstacles	7
Visual Examples	8

General Information

Game Title: Ruler of the Tomb

Genre: Text-Based & Choice Driven RPG

Target Audience:

Platform: Windows PC

Engine: Windows Console

Programming Language: C#

Story & Setting

The player plays as a skeleton, their goal is to reach the bottom of the tomb and fight the ruler, the Legend King. On the way the player encounters a small variety of fights and rooms to prepare themselves for the upcoming fight. Some gear is blessed, other gear is cursed, the player's decisions leading to one of the two, or neither. The gear choice leads to a set of status effects, and depending on the status of the player, they will get a different ending.

Most of the blessed and cursed gear is optional. But before the final fight there will be an encounter that results in the status being somewhat guaranteed for the player.

The story has 3 endings, two endings for winning with cursed or blessed status, and one ending for losing to the King. Any other death results in a generic game-over. There's a total of 5 scenes, 6 if you count the ending as its own scene and 8 if you count all 3 endings as their own scenes.

Gameplay Loop

The game is rather linear, and doesn't have any choices that impact the story's dialogue or ending. The thing that decides the ending is purely up to the player's status by the end of the game or whether or not they lose. Choices do come with extra dialogue in scenes, but the next scene won't change as a result of a choice.

Start Game → Scene 1 (Explore) → Scene 2 (Explore) – Scene 2 (Combat)
→ Scene 3 (Exploration) → Riddle → Combat (avoidable)
→ Scene 4 Choice → Scene 5 (Combat) → Scene 6 (Final Fight + Ending)
 [Blessed] → Ruler Ending
 [Cursed] → Tyrant Ending
 [Lose to Boss] → Bad Ending

Unique Mechanic

The unique mechanic of this game is the “Blessed” and “Cursed” status effect. It provides different passives in battle, and it decides the ending for the player. The player is also punished for ignoring it by making the final fight that much harder without it.

Game Rules

Player Health reaches 0 = Game Over

Player Health reaches 0 in Final Boss = Bad Ending

Player has a status that changes between “lucky” and “blessed” or “hexed” and “cursed”.

Lucky is applied if the player has 1 blessed item equipped

Blessed is achieved if the player has 2 blessed items equipped

Hexed is applied if the player has 1 cursed item equipped

Cursed is achieved if the player has 2 cursed items equipped

If the player is neither blessed or cursed, they will be in the “Normal” status.

In the fight before the final fight, the player will be forced to obtain an invisible item that grants them a different passive depending on who they kill first. If the player never obtains a blessed or cursed item, or has a 50/50 split on blessed and cursed items this is the item that will decide the ending.

More Lucky or Blessed items held = Good ending

More Hexed or Cursed items held = Evil Ending

Each status comes with a passive.

Lucky increases critical hit chance. Blessed removes the crit chance of the lucky status but provides the player with a single free and automatic self-revive if they die in battle.

Hexed increases dodge chance by an extreme amount, but deals damage to the player every turn. Cursed status removes the hexed status dodge chance and DoT effect, and replaces it with a huge boost to damage dealt that serves as the only way to outdamage the boss, but at the cost of recoil damage (the excuse being that the player’s brittle bones cannot handle the power of each blow).

A Game Over automatically sends the player back to Room 1 to start over without a prompt to restart. The game only closes itself or ends when the player reaches an ending.

Each scene clearly establishes that it’s the next scene/room. At most there are 5 scenes and each scene will have 1 fight or less. One of the scenes will be a sort of “break room” where the player is healed before the next fight, and given a helpful tip, or powerful item for free in order to increase the chances against the final boss. The game has 3 to 4 fights, one of the fights being avoidable if the player answers a riddle correctly.

The player has no magic meter, just skills with limited uses, like PP in Pokémon. With the only skill that has no limit on how much it’s used being the default attack.

Enemies and Obstacles

The game has 4 enemies for the player to fight.

Each one serves a different challenge and provides a different reward.

Fight 1 is an aggressive skeleton not unlike the player that was defeated and left behind with most of his bones destroyed. Despite this, his equipment makes him quite strong, and since he's blocking the way into the next room, you're forced to fight him. Exploring the room in the right order has you notice a trap. Noticing this trap allows you to notice it before the opponent gets crushed by it, but the skeleton's desperate final swing of the fight destroys his weapon as a result. The alternative is that the trap crushes him, destroying his armor, but causing his weapon (a mace) to drop on the floor. To actually get the item, the player has to search the opponent's body after the fight to pick up the gear, otherwise they missed it.

Fight 2 is a treasure chest that the player has the choice to ignore. However, interacting with it has the chest speak and give you a riddle. Answer correctly and he'll give you something nice (a blessed sword), answer incorrectly or don't answer after talking to him and he will attack, starting a fight with the game's second enemy. Beating him in combat will give you a different item (a cursed shield).

The scene after is a sort of interlude where the player can either get one of two hints on how to use the blessed or cursed gear they obtained, and what each status does. Or they can get an item that provides a scroll, giving the player a spell that allows them to heal themselves or deal 2.5x more damage for their next attack. The spell they get is random, both allowing for a strategy to more easily beat the final boss.

Fight 3 is the last fight before the final boss. The two henchmen guarding the door to the boss's room, one is called "Radiant Warrior" and the other is the "Dull Scholar". Depending on which one of the two the player beats first, they will get a blessed or cursed item that provides a small passive effect without having to equip it. The blessed item gives the passive of providing two acts per-turn, and the cursed item gives the passive of boosting all stats a decent amount. This is the only way in the entire game to boost the stats of the player, and can only be used for the final battle.

Fight 4 is the final boss. The King of the Tomb. He'll basically be an optimized version of the "cursed" player that attacks on a set pattern. He'll have equal/higher stats, the same skills, with both magic spells and an extra spell that the player cannot get, that being a powerful fireball. The fireball takes 4 turns to charge and will defeat the player in one hit, only being survivable by enduring with 1HP if the player blocks the attack, alternatively allowing for the revive passive of a fully blessed player to come in handy. The idea for the boss is that blessed players are intended to outlast him, and cursed players are intended to kill him before he can use his fireball attack. It's basically a damage check that's made easier depending on how much of one gear-type they have, and nearly impossible if the player skipped getting any and all of the cursed and blessed gear.

Final boss is the last enemy, resulting in an ending depending on the amount of blessed or cursed items the player owns.

Visual Examples

The game is going to run in the Windows Console, so it'll all purely be text.

Each scene/room starts with a "Starting Scene" that describes the room and establishes how the player got there from the previous room. After that, they get a list of choices that lead to various events within the scene until they reach the main conflict of that scene. Exploring will usually give hints on how to do the room "properly" and get the blessed item. Going through the room as quickly as possible will most likely result in getting a cursed item, as the player themselves will miss an interaction that locks them out of getting the blessed item, or they'll answer something wrong, resulting in the fight that leads to the cursed item. Basically, blessed is the result of intentional and thorough exploration, cursed is a result of carelessness that usually happens on repeat playthroughs, the idea being that everyone in the tomb will eventually become cursed once they've awoken in the tomb too many times.

So the structure is like this:

1. Scene Introduction
2. Scene Choice & Exploration
 - a. Events
 - b. Combat
3. Post-Battle Scene
4. Leftover exploration
5. Scene ends → Next Scene

The only exception being the interlude scene that follows this structure instead

1. Scene Introduction
2. Scene Choice
 - a. Hint for Blessed Builds
 - b. Hint for Cursed Builds
 - c. Item to make final fight easier
3. Scene ends → Next Scene

And the final Scene which follows this structure:

1. Scene Introduction
2. Combat
 - a. Victory
 - i. Ending 1 or Ending 2 (Depending on cursed or blessed gear owned)
 - b. Defeat
 - i. Ending 3 (Bad ending for losing to the boss)

If possible I want the scenes and choices to be done through text inputs and commands. While I want combat to be done through mouse inputs, and clicking menu prompts